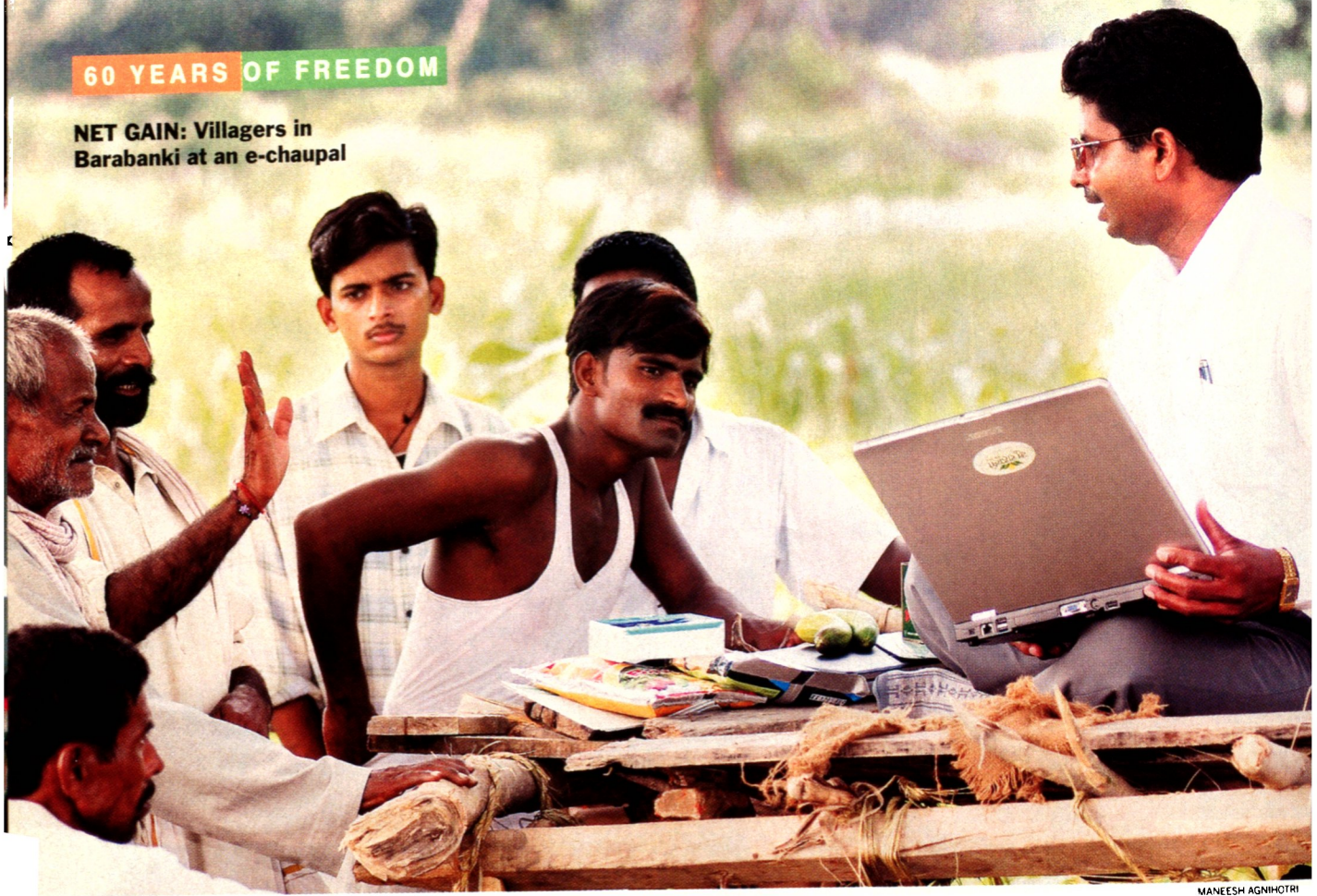


60 YEARS OF FREEDOM

NET GAIN: Villagers in Barabanki at an e-chaupal



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

E-CHAUPAL

Barabanki | UTTAR PRADESH



Informed choices

IT has changed the way farmers operate in this tiny village, eliminating middlemen and arming them with information

■ By Subhash Mishra

For years, farmers such as Ram Suchit, 46, were victims of local brokers selling spurious fertilisers and seeds, conniving middlemen and merciless market forces.

But now, every time Suchit, a resident of Satrikh village in Barabanki district, has a problem, he visits the Hariyali Krishi Kendra (HKK) that runs an e-chaupal for on-the-spot redressal of farming problems. Operated by Rohtas Private Limited, HKK is a small agri-mall that provides information to farmers regarding their agricultural requirements—seeds, fertilisers and pesticides—at just the click of a button. This initiative uses technology to empower and enrich the farmers with information. The digital transformation has revolutionised the whole agricultural

set-up by providing information on all issues related to farming. It has also eliminated touts who used to gain at the expense of the hapless farmers. “On an average, we get 20 queries from farmers every day,” says L.S. Bhandari, HKK manager.

Information is power. Ram Kumar, a 50-year-old paddy farmer agrees, “We never knew the rates of produce outside our region, Barabanki. But this system helps us check the prices in other cities and send the produce to destinations where we may get higher amounts.” Compared to the previous season, farmers have gained Rs 200 more for every quintal sold with the intervention of the HKK.

Similarly Sankrati Mishra, 25, another farmer who depended on traditional wisdom to deal with pests that affected his crop, says he often used certain pesticides without realising that they would not work on all crops. “But we discuss the problem with the agri-consultant who in turn checks different websites and recommends the required pesticide,” he says.

3.5

MILLION FARMERS HAVE ACCESS TO ITC'S E-CHOU PAL SERVICES IN OVER 38,500 VILLAGES THROUGH NEARLY 6,500 KIOSKS